ENVIRONMENT

A WARMING WARNING

As India reels under extreme heat on a planet already 1.5 degrees Celsius warmer, forecasters warn of a Super El Niño—on the scale of the 1876-78 catastrophe—that could disrupt rainfall across much of the country, with major consequences for the economy

Graphic by **NILANJAN DAS**

Text by **JUMANA SHAH**

82%
probability of El Niño emerging in May-July

98.4%
chance that 2026 will rank among the five warmest years on record

THE SUPER EL NIÑO YEARS

1876-78
One of the deadliest El Niño events on record triggered famines. Estimated global death toll: 30-60 mn, India: 5.5-10 mn

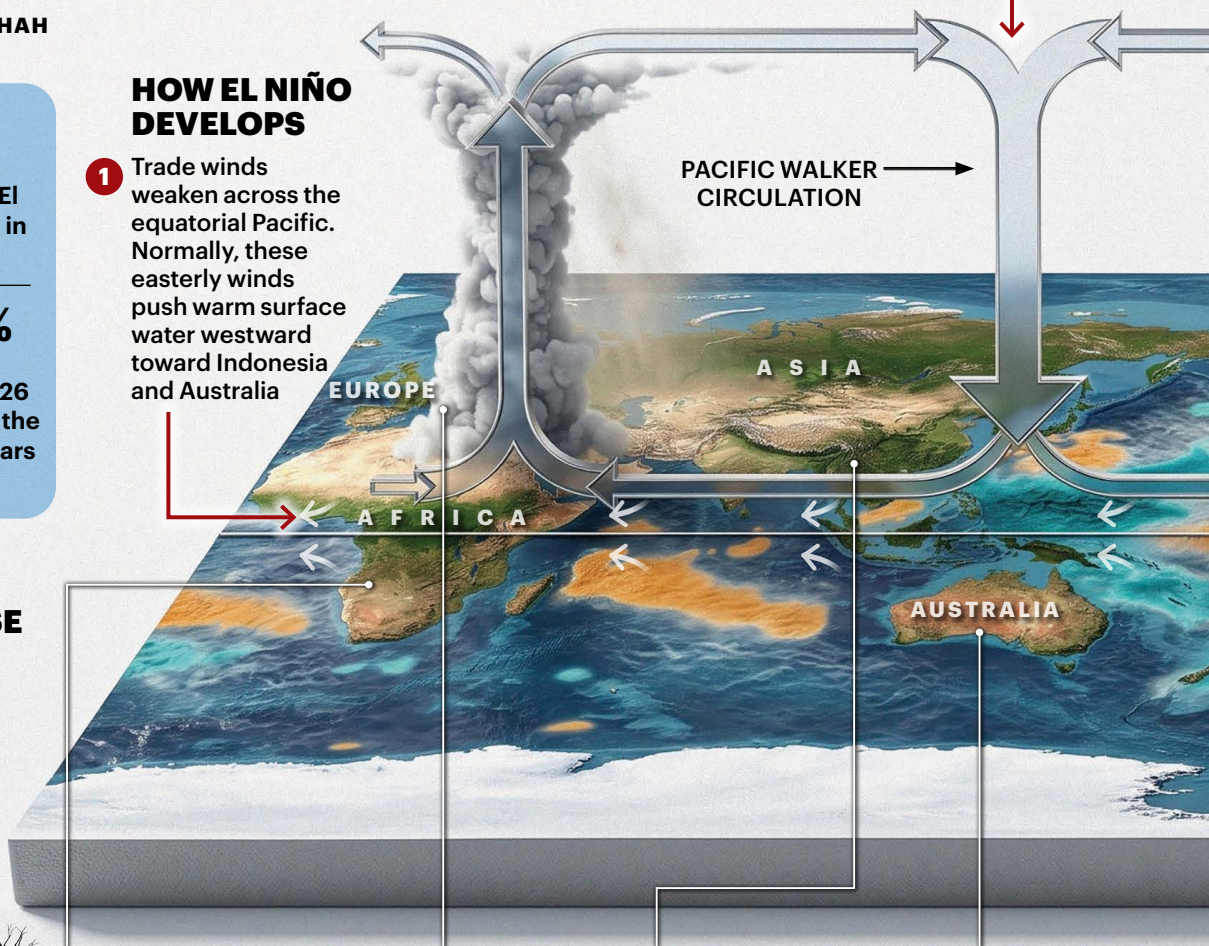
1997-98
The strongest El Niño of the 20th century killed 23,000 people and caused $5.7 trillion in global losses over five years

2015-16
Sixty million people needed food aid worldwide. India faced monsoon deficits. Drought intensified agrarian crisis

HOW EL NIÑO DEVELOPS

1. Trade winds weaken across the equatorial Pacific. Normally, these easterly winds push warm surface water westward toward Indonesia and Australia

4. The Walker circulation weakens (sometimes reversing) as rising air and low pressure shift eastward across the Pacific, while sinking air and high pressure build over Indonesia and the western Pacific



TYPICAL REGION-WISE IMPACT OF EL NIÑO

AFRICA
Droughts in some areas, food insecurity, heavier floods in East Africa



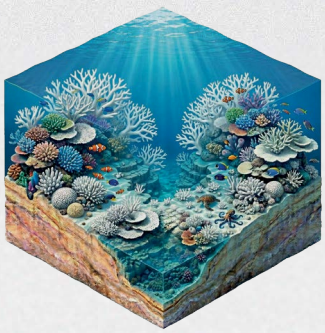
EUROPE
Milder winters in the North, wetter Mediterranean





SOUTHEAST ASIA
Drought, forest fires, transboundary smoke haze, falling palm oil and rice output

AUSTRALIA
Heatwaves, drought, bushfires, water shortages, coral bleaching on the Great Barrier Reef



Sources: The US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, India Meteorological Department, World Bank, Indian Council of Agricultural Research, EY